Taliban, whether Afghani or Pakistani, all came from Pakistani madrasahs, whose strength increased from approximately 250 in 1947 to 11,000 registered persons at present. The unregistered madrasahs, at a conservative estimate, could number another 45,000 (Ahmed, 2009). However, it is wrong to interpret that Pakistani Taliban are from madrasahs. Pakistani Taliban or TTP were not particularly the madrasah students like Afghan students. Rather most of them were non-madrasahs.

According to an ICG report, during the independence of Pakistan in 1947, there were barely 137 madrasahs. In April 2002, Mahmood Ahmed Ghazi, the Minister of Religious Affairs, stated that there were 10,000 with 1.7 million students. They belonged to the major sects of Islam, the Sunnis and the Shiʿa. Pakistan is a predominantly Sunni country, so the number of Shiʿa were much less. Among the Sunnis, there are three sub-sects, namely Deobandis, Barelvis and the Ahl-e-Hadith (salafi). Besides, the revivalist Jamat-e-Islami also had its own madrasahs (Rehman, 2004).

Yet another report stated that until 2011 there were approximately 24,000 madrasahs (*Express Tribune*, 2011)[5] registered with six distinct madrasah networks, divided along the sectarian lines. There was no credible information on the unregistered madrasahs. However, the registered ones were controlled by their own central organisations or boards. They determined the syllabi and collected registration fees and examination fees. They used to send examination papers, in Urdu and Arabic, to pupils in the madrasahs and declare results. The names of the boards are as follows:

(1) Wafaq ul Madaris Deobandi Multan 1958;
(2) Tanzim ul Madaris Barelvi Lahore 1960;
(3) Wafaq ul Madaris (Shiʿa) Pakistan Shiʿa Lahore 1962;
(4) Rabta-tul-Madaris-al-Islamia Jamat-i-Islami Lahore 1986;
(5) Wafq-ul-Madaris-al-Salafia Ahl-e-Hadith Faisalabad 1978.

General Zia-ul-Haq's military rule (1977–88) proved to be a turning point for the madrasah system as the number of madrasahs increased rapidly. During the war by Islamic Afghan groups in Afghanistan against the Soviet Union, the US was said to have supported the madrasahs by sending money, arms and ammunition through Pakistan.

Later, presumably because religiously inspired and madrasah students infiltrated across the line of control to fight the Indian army in Kashmir,